in November 1952

- Dag Hammarskjöld (Sweden), from April 1953 till his death in a plane crash near Nodola, Northern Rhodesia (now Zambia) in September 1961
- U Thant (Burma, now Myanmar), from November 1961, appointed as acting Secretary-General and formally from November 1962 to December 1971
- Kurt Waldheim (Austria), from January 1972 to December 1981
- Javier Pèrez de Cuèllar (Peru), from January 1982 to December 1991
- Boutros Boutros-Ghali (Egypt), from January 1992 to December 1996
- Kofi Annan (Ghana), from 1997 to December 2006
- Ban Ki-moon of the Republic of Korea (South Korea), who took office on 1 January 2007.
- António Guterres (Portugal), is the Ninth Secretary General of the UN. He took office on 1 January, 2017.

Secretariat

In the performance of his duties in the spirit of the Charter, the Secretary-General, is assisted by a staff who are expected to exhibit the highest standards of efficiency, competence, and integrity. He makes the necessary appointments according to the regulations established by the General Assembly under Article 101[1]. Under Article 101[2], appropriate staff shall be permanently assigned to the Economic and Social Council, the Trusteeship Council and, as required, to other organs of the United Nations. All these staff form part of the Secretariat. The prime consideration is placed in the employment of the staff and in the determination of the conditions of service to secure the highest standards of efficiency, competence, and integrity. Due regard shall be paid to the importance of recruiting the staff on as wide a geographical basis as possible.

The staff of the Secretariat comprise linguists, economists, editors, social scientists, legal experts, experts in the various fields of UN activities, librarians, journalists, statisticians, broadcasters, personnel